

Today we turn to our third big question. This question can be introduced by an example.

Suppose that in the year 2069 the surviving members of this Introduction to Philosophy class decided to have an Intro to Philosophy reunion, and all gathered in this room. Suppose that they decided to get a group picture taken.

Now imagine that, via some sort of time travel device, I now have that photo, and show it to you. You might ask: Am I one of those people? Which one am I?

It is very natural to assume that these questions must have determinate answers. There must be some fact of the matter about whether one of the people in the photo is you. And, if one is you, there must be some fact of the matter about which one is you.

Let's suppose that this is true: there must be a fact about whether you survive to be
in this picture, and must be a fact about which of the survivors you are.

Then we can ask a question about these facts:

**The survival
question:** What does it
take for for some
person at some other
time to be you?

To introduce our main answers to the survival question, it will be useful to think about a simple, uncontroversial example of survival.

All of you believe that you will wake up tomorrow in your bed. To put the same point another way, all of you believe that the person now sitting in your seat is the same person as — identical to — the person who will wake up in your bed tomorrow morning.

What do we mean when we say that you are identical to that person?

Here it is important to get clear at the outset on one distinction which, if not attended to, can make these questions more confusing than they have to be.

This is the distinction between **numerical** and **qualitative** identity.

To say that x and y are numerically identical is to say that they are literally the same thing — they are one, not two.

To say that x and y things are qualitatively identical is to say that they are exactly resembling — they have just the same properties.

When we say that you are identical to the person who will get out of your bed tomorrow morning, we are not of course saying that you are qualitatively identical to that person. Their hair will be messed up, and they will be wearing different clothes.

Rather, we mean that you are numerically identical to that person: there is just

one person who is today in this class, and is tomorrow morning in that bed.

Let's look at some answers to the survival question.

There are three main answers to that question (though, we will see, they can also be combined in interesting ways).



**materialist
survival**

Our first answer is also the simplest one. This says that you are the same person as the person who will wake up in that bed tomorrow because you are the same material thing as that person.

On one natural version of this view, you are an organism — a member of the species *homo sapiens*. The explanation of the fact that you are identical to the person waking up in your bed tomorrow is fundamentally the same as the explanation of the fact that my dog is the same dog as the one who will wake up in his crate tomorrow morning. It the same as the explanation of why a tree that has lost its leaves is the same tree as the one that had leaves in the summer.

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the 1990s, the number of people in the UK who are aged 65 and over has increased from 10.5 million to 13.5 million, and the number of people aged 75 and over has increased from 4.5 million to 6.5 million (Office for National Statistics 2000).

There is a growing awareness of the need to address the needs of older people in the community. The Department of Health (1999) has published a strategy for older people, which sets out a vision for the future of older people's health and social care. The strategy is based on the following principles:

- Older people should be able to live independently in their own homes for as long as possible.
- Older people should be able to access the services and support they need to live independently.
- Older people should be able to participate in the decisions that affect their lives.
- Older people should be able to live in a safe and secure environment.

The strategy also sets out a number of key objectives for the future of older people's health and social care. These include:

- Improving the health and well-being of older people.
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